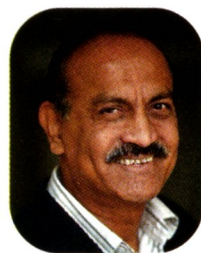


21UP↑ I RAJ CHENGAPPA

The Earth in ICU



For a species that is facing the gravest threat to its sole habitat we seem to be pretty casual about saving it as the recently concluded Climate Change Conference at Copenhagen demonstrated. You could forgive the dinosaurs—they didn't know that a meteorite was going to clobber the earth leading to catastrophic climate changes and their rapid extinction. But we have enough proof that at the present rate of emission of greenhouse gases we are barely five years away from crossing the tipping point in temperatures that would result in irreversible and devastating climate change. The earth is already in the ICU.

True, US President Barack Obama brilliantly pulled off a face-saver by barging into confabulations, breaking protocol and coming up with some eleventh-hour statesmanship that produced the Copenhagen Accord. And the so-called BASIC countries—Brazil, South Africa, India and China—can claim equal credit for pulling the negotiations back from the brink of total failure. Obama had come with a determination to get China—and to some extent India—take on legally binding emission cuts. So, rolling up his sleeves he argued with the BASIC leaders that the emission intensity reduction commitments they had made should be verifiable by the international community. He had wanted words like 'review', 'verification', 'scrutiny' and 'investigation' to be used in the document while the BASIC group preferred terms such as 'dialogue' and 'discussion'. In the end, the compromise words were "consultation and analysis", and the accord was reached.

Instead of starting from scratch again, nations have a template to work on in the coming months. What the Accord did was to postpone the obvious: that industrialised nations have to come up with even deeper legally binding emission cuts than what they promised under the Kyoto Protocol apart from providing substantial amounts of finance and technology to help developing countries. Post the Accord, there is the sorry spectacle of leaders of each of the nations going back home and claiming credit for defending their national interests. Obama's spin doctors were busy telling their domestic audience that he had pinned down China and India. In the Rajya Sabha, Environment Minister Jairam Ramesh, with his characteristic eloquence, claimed that India had not become a pall-bearer for the Kyoto Protocol. Later he would more candidly admit, "What nations did at Copenhagen was not save humanity but just their national interests." Unfortunately, as in an all-out nuclear war, nations would soon realise that in climate change there are no winners—only survivors.

POST THE COP-OUT, THERE IS THE SORRY SPECTACLE OF EACH NATION CLAIMING CREDIT FOR DEFENDING ITS INTERESTS IN THE ACCORD.



PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com

SIGNPOSTS

PASSED: By the Gujarat Assembly, the **Gujarat Local Authorities Laws (Amendment) Bill** which makes voting mandatory. This is the first time in the country that voting in local body polls has been made compulsory.

SENTENCED: Former Haryana director-general of police **SPS Rathore** to six

KESHAV SINGH



months imprisonment for molesting a 14-year-old tennis player in 1990.

WON: By the **Indian wrestling team**, all seven gold medals in freestyle events at the Commonwealth Wrestling Championships in Jalandhar, winning 16 of the overall 21 golds.

DIED: Tennis player **Vishnu Mohan**, 83, former India No. 3 who played in the mixed doubles at Wimbledon in 1955.

RANKED: Reliance Industries CEO **Mukesh Ambani** among the world's five best performing CEOs by *Harvard Business Review*. He is the only Indian to figure in the top 50 CEOs.